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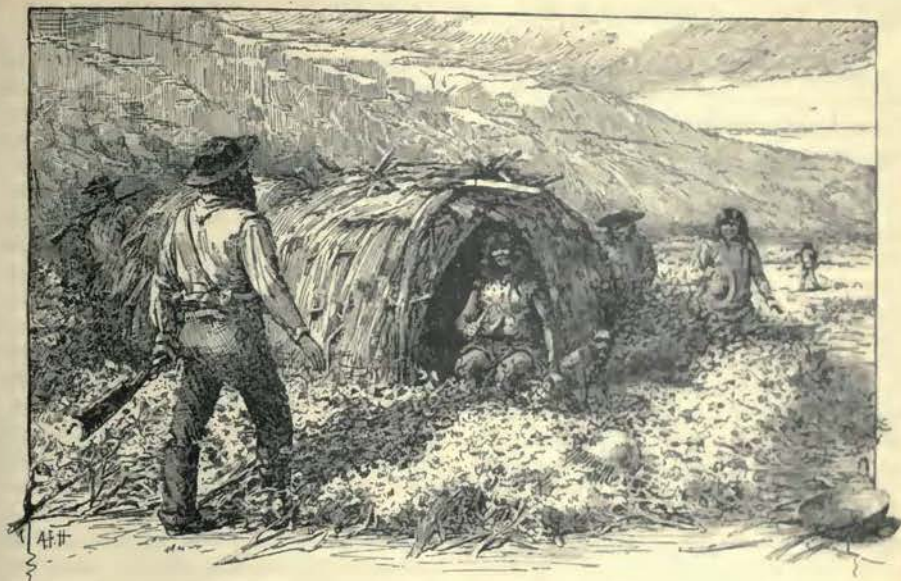


TABLE OF CONTENTS

THE WILD WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS	By A. HARMER	Frontispiece
TWILIGHT	JEAN LA RUE BURNETT	621
TESTIMONIES	FRANK WALCOTT HUTT	623
FIESOLANA	GRACE ELLERY CHANNING	623
Illustrated from photographs.		
AROUND THE GARDEN OF THE GODS	J. J. PEATFIELD	632
Illustrated from photographs.		
THE PROFESSIONAL BEAUTIES OF JAPAN	HELEN GREGORY-FLESHER	643
Illustrated from photographs and drawings.		
TO CALIFORNIA'S GRATE FIRES	MINNA V. GADEN	660
THE WILD WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS	JAMES M. GIBBONS	661
Illustrated from drawings by A. Harmer.		
MY "BUNKY"	ROBERT HOWE FLETCHER, U.S.A.	667
HAS THE REPUBLICAN PARTY A FUTURE?	R. H. McDONALD, JR.	675
ON KEATS	LORENZO SOSSO	680
CALIFORNIA AS A HEALTH RESORT	P. C. REMONDINO, M.D.	681
A GROUP OF ARMY AUTHORS	C. C. BATEMAN, U.S.A.	684
Illustrated from photographs.		
ALONE	ALBERT MONSON	693
FRA DIAVOLO OF EL DORADO	NEITH BOYCE	695
Illustrated from drawings by A. Harmer.		
THE DEERHOUND IN AMERICA	GEORGE MACDOUGALL	701
Illustrated from photographs.		
THAT ALIEN	ROSALIE A. KNELL	709
QUESTIONS OF THE DAY		716
BOOKS AND AUTHORS		718



THE WILD WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS



THE WILD WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS ISLAND.

BY JAMES M. GIBBONS.



IF we could form a mental picture of San Nicolas Island as it appeared half a century ago, we should find its physical features the same as those which it presents to-day—a rocky, wave-beaten finger-tip of nature peeping above the surface of the Pacific nearly due southwest of Los Angeles, moss-carpeted where the brushwood has found no soil wherein to take root, and rising in the centre so as to form a hill with somewhat steep declivities. We should perceive at the base of this eminence springs of fresh water which would supply the unfortunate mariner who might have the ill-luck to be cast away on that uninviting shore. Wild dogs would be seen roaming about or stealthily creeping

up to the seals that lay basking in the sun and slumbering on the craggy rocks and beach, while shags perched on peaks and slabs plume their oily feathers in the warm rays. The twittering of small birds in the brush might also form part of this mental impression. These would seem to be the only signs of animal life on the island, and our first impression would be that it was uninhabited by human being. A closer scrutiny, however, would reveal to us on the mainland side of the hill three small brushwood huts with frameworks of the bones of the whale, and a low brush fence before them as a wind-break. In front of one of these lowly huts would be seen a woman squatted on the ground engaged in weaving a water vessel, or bottle, her textile material being grass fibre, of which she had an abundance at hand, collected from the margins of springs and the moist, swampy patches which occupy the nooks and recesses of the island. Ever and anon she raises

her eyes from her work, gazing wistfully seaward, and if a vessel should heave in sight she would be seen to rise excitedly, calling out "Manequauna" at the top of her voice and frantically waving her arms. Then, as the vessel bears away, dipping and rising with the billows, its crew unconscious of her call for rescue, she "puts her head on the ground and lies on the ground and weeps." She is a very comely woman of the Indian race, though her features are weather-worn and her hair matted and sun-bleached. Her well-developed, muscular figure is displayed under her tightly fitting coat, which with Indian patience she has made out of the skins of shags caught by night while asleep on the crags by the shore. The lone Indian on that little sea-girt isle is the Wild Woman of San Nicolas Island.

The story of the Wild Woman of San Nicolas Island is a singular one. Outlines and summaries of it have been published from time to time, but a full account has never been given, nor has any part of it been presented as related by the principal actors engaged in her rescue after she had lived in solitude for seventeen years on that lonely isle. That it can be so given now is due to the zeal and thoughtfulness of Mr. D. W. Thompson, one of the fathers of the City of Flowers, and to him we are indebted for a decidedly curious page of history. In 1882 Mr. Thompson, accompanied by a short-hand reporter, sought out those principal actors—the venerable pioneers George Nidever and Charles Brown—and by elaborate questioning obtained full particulars connected with the unfortunate woman's career. From their statements we are enabled to furnish the following narrative of facts.

George Nidever was born in Tennessee in 1802, and left home when only ten years old to follow the vocation of a hunter and trapper. The first field of his operations was

Arkansas; thence he proceeded to Texas, which at that time belonged to Mexico. Returning to Arkansas, he joined a company which left for the Rocky Mountains to trap beaver. At starting the party was forty-eight strong, and, ever pushing westward, thirty-six of them, among whom was Nidever, finally reached Monterey in 1834, twelve of their number having dropped out by the way. The journey occupied several years of adventurous travel, during which time the party subsisted on buffalo, deer, and bear meat, experiencing much annoyance from Indians, who stole their skins and otherwise molested them. After reaching California, Nidever settled down at Santa Barbara in 1835 and engaged in sea-otter hunting, a vocation which he pursued for thirty years, during the earlier part of which period he took part in several conflicts with Indians.

Charles Brown, whose real name is Carl Ditman, was twenty years Nidever's junior, having been born in Prussia in 1822. He followed the sea for ten or twelve years, and reached California in 1844, sailing under Captain Wilson. He also engaged in otter-hunting, and has remained permanently in the country ever since his arrival.

It is conjectured by these pioneers that all the Santa Barbara Islands were settled by Indians, who according to Brown were much molested by the tribes from the northwest. These warlike savages would cross the channel in their canoes and hunt and shoot the poor islanders, "just for mischief." Whatever may have been the reason for adopting such a measure, the Mexican government, Nidever informs us, decided to remove the Indians dwelling on the island to the mainland and distribute them among the missions. It is with the removal of those on San Nicolas that our narrative is concerned.

The small schooner sent by the authorities to bring off the family,

which consisted of seven or eight members, was called *Better-than-Nothing* and was in command of an old sea-otter hunter named Sparks. They succeeded in getting all on board except the woman, who, though brought down to the beach, was so distracted at her two children having been left behind that they let her go back and sailed away. There is some doubt whether she had one child or two, but Mr. Brown says: "I understand she made plain signs; showed two fingers for two children. She shook her breast; one was nursing and the other had teeth. She sucked her fingers." Little it matters now whether she had one or two babies: the cruel fact remains that the poor creature was abandoned to her fate by Sparks and his crew, heartless semi-savage hunters who recked little of the life of an Indian. To judge from reports handed down, it may be inferred that she returned to the beach before the schooner was at any great distance from the shore. Otherwise how could such a detail originate and become current as this narrated by Brown? "When she got there [the lower part of the island] she found the vessel going away. She called 'Manequauna!' They made signs to her that they would come back. She put her head on the ground and laid on the ground and cried; and they never came." And again he says: "They told her they would come back to-morrow, but they never came back." So she was left to return to her desolate hut, with the wild dogs and the sea-birds' cry rising above the hoarse murmur of the surf howling by night around her. Nidever states that after she was brought off the island by him seventeen years later she made signs that her child had been devoured by the wild dogs. Those creatures were numerous on the island at that time, but were poisoned off many years later. The same authority informs us that it was the intention of Sparks to go back for her, but the schooner

was lost soon afterward on a voyage to San Francisco, and then adds: "All thought the woman would not live long, so they did not go back." The reader must form his own conclusion with regard to this sad episode.

It is not difficult to picture to one's self the condition and miseries of this lonely woman, separated from husband and family and dependent on herself for every necessity of life. We can see her day by day gazing seaward, on the watch for the boat. The days summed up into months and months grew into years, but no schooner returned. She saw ships going by, this way and that, but nobody came for her. Her cry of "Manequauna" was unheeded, and as time lapsed she became adapted to circumstances and her surroundings. With deft fingers she wove baskets and water-tight vessels, smearing the latter with melted asphaltum; she twisted the sinews of seals, which she caught while sleeping, into fishing-lines; she dug up the succulent roots of plants and roasted them over fire obtained by rubbing two sticks together; and clothed herself in sea-bird skins which she sewed together with fine sinew with the aid of needles made of bone. As the years passed by she became contented with her lot; time dulled her grief, and she accepted the situation with the stoical resignation of her race. Fish, seal flesh, and roots formed her diet; pure spring water was her only beverage. Once she fell deadly sick, lying helpless on the ground for days before she recovered. Pioneer Brown says: "She made signs that she had been sick, lying in the dirt for days. She could not move; all alone, she was down sick and got well."

But the day arrived when the white man again interfered with the current of her life, and with fatal result. The time came at last when she was to leave her island home. It seems to have been suspected, if not confidently understood, that a wild woman

was living on San Nicolas Island, for Padre Gonzales, of Santa Barbara, requested Nidever to search for her. "I went over three times," he says, "before I found her." On the last expedition Nidever took over several Indians in addition to two or three white men as crew, Pioneer Brown being also on board. Reverencing first-hand matter more than literary form, we will quote the words of the aged pioneer's dictation as he narrated the circumstances attending the finding of her: "We took all ashore except the cook. We thought she would try and hide, and we scattered off, two or three hundred yards apart. She had a little house made of brush, and had a fire. Sitting by the fire with a little knife, she was working with it. She had a bone. All came up and looked at her well. She had

a heap of roots. That is what she lived on; she had little sacks to carry them in. As soon as we sat down she put a lump of them to roast on the fire. Finally we got ready to go, and made signs for her to come with us. She understood the signs, for she picked up her things to take them on board. She did not appear to be seasick at all, and was contented. Next day we moved ashore and stayed there a month and killed a good many otter. She appeared to like everything we had to eat. She was very willing to come with us."

Brown is much more circumstantial in his account, which may be explained by the facts that, being so much younger than Nidever, his memory of the occurrence was more retentive of particulars, and that he was the principal actor in the search.

From his dictation we learn that Nidever had previously to this third visit to the island seen signs of the Indian woman, but had afterward failed to find the tracks. On the occasion when Brown accompanied him, the weather was stormy, and it was three days before they could effect a landing. It will be interesting to many readers of the CALIFORNIAN and only justice to the old pioneer himself to quote from his dictation some portion of the account he gives of the finding of the Wild Woman. He says:

"I went round the head of the island and found tracks of the woman; went back and told the old gentleman that the wom-



THE WILD WOMAN AT WORK.

an was alive. He said it must be some of our Indians. I said, 'Our Indians have got bigger tracks than that.' He said, 'Well, if you think she is alive, let us hunt for her, and take all the men ashore.' We went up to the head of the island. There was a kind of hill in the middle. I put my Indians a couple of hundred yards apart. I did not know what kind of woman she was, thought she might bite or scratch. We went from one side of the island to the other and could not see the hill, and she was sitting on the side of the hill watching us. When we got across to the Indians I said, 'There's nothing here, let's go back.' There was a basket and some feathers. She caught shags and had a coat made without sleeves, nicely covered with seal-skin. I said to the Indians, 'You go to the hill and scatter the feathers and things in the basket, and if she is alive she will find them.' The same day we found them all gathered up again and put in the basket."

On the following morning Brown persistently continued the hunt. Toiling up the hill, when he was about half-way up, he caught sight of her. She was carrying something heavy, and rested at intervals as she ascended. Presently he came in sight of "three huts made out of whale-bone. Here he expected to find her, but peering in found that she was not there. Presently he espied "something like a crow sitting on a whale-bone," and perceiving that it was the woman he was in search of, he raised his gun with his hat on it as a signal to the Indians whom he hastily summoned, as he did not know if she would "bite or scratch." He thus continues his narration:

"She had a brush fence, about two feet high, to break the wind, and right in front of me she sat facing me. The sun was coming in her face. She was skinning a seal before I came up to her. The dog, when he noticed me, began to growl. Think-

ing she might run I stepped round her, and she bowed as if she knew me before, and when the Indians came up they all kneeled." The poor creature, when she saw beings of her own color and race, "held out some of her food" to them. She exhibited no fear, and at a sign went without demur with her captors, if such they can be called, though she afterward gave them to understand that she would not have joined them if they had not found her. Brown and his followers carried away with them all her primitive belongings. "I took everything she had," he says, "and she took a big seal-head in her basket, and that was all. We all had something to carry." Arriving at a watering-place "she washed herself over. Her hair was all rotting away, and kind of bleached by the sun." When they reached the vessel she kneeled and crawled to the stove which was on deck. Brown gave her some biscuit which she enjoyed, and made petticoats and skirts for her out of bed-ticking and sailors' clothes.

During their month's stay at the island, the Wild Woman was perfectly well and happy with her new friends. She camped out with them, living on the same food that they did, fetching fuel and water for herself, and returning to camp without making any attempt to escape. In camp she would "play like a child," or occupy herself in making baskets, working at a dozen or more of them. She worked on one and then on the other, never finishing them. She liked potatoes, rice, and fish; she did not eat much, but often, just like a child. Brown narrates a touching incident which marks the sympathy of this child of nature for dumb animals and her kindly disposition. She had a young sea-otter, and to prevent the sun from shining in its eyes, she rigged up a shade with sticks and hung it over the little creature.

On their return to the mainland they encountered rough weather, yet the Wild Woman would not stay be-

low, but remained on deck making signs to the men "to pray for the wind to go down." On their passage they discovered that she had names for all the islands, but Brown could not recollect them. "When we came to Santa Barbara beach there was nobody living there except old man Nidever. Seeing the boys coming along on horses, she thought it was awful; and when she saw the cattle she crawled on the sand beach on her hands and knees."

When the Wild Woman reached Santa Barbara all her family were dead. They had been taken to San Pedro, where they pined and died under the Indian-destroying wand of civilization; so nobody could understand her dialect. The priests tried hard to get her life's story from her, but her gibberish was unintelligible. Indians were brought to her from Ventura, Santa Barbara, and other places, but they could only understand a few words spoken by her. Nidever states that efforts were made to find some tribe that could talk with her, but without success. Finally an old woman who had been raised on one of the islands was found who could understand what she said to a limited extent; but most of her communications were made by means of signs.

At the Mission of Santa Barbara the Wild Woman was baptized under the Christian name of Juana Maria, as Brown thinks, though not feeling certain on that point. From one of the men who had sailed in the little schooner *Better-than-Nothing* she received the name of that vessel. Wild Woman is a misnomer. Brown, who before he became acquainted with her entertained a judicious apprehension as to the diversified capabilities of her teeth and finger-nails, makes this remark: "They all asked me if she was wild. She was not wild." Poor harmless, childlike creature, with a great capacity for happiness, she enjoyed her new life, and displayed no symptoms of feroc-

ity. Says Nidever: "She would go round to different homes and dance Indian dances. She went all over town and the Mission, always a party of twenty or thirty Indians and Mexicans with her." Brown corroborates this testimony as to her contentment: "Happy as a lady. She would dance when any one came in." Clothes were her especial delight. The woman was a great curiosity, and Nidever, who had taken her into his house, was offered \$1,000 to part with her, the object of the would-be purchaser being to exhibit her. To his lasting honor he refused to make such a bargain, because "it did not look right to me to sell a person."

But the end was drawing near. Change of diet cut short the life of the luckless Juana Maria, who would doubtless have lived many years longer had she been allowed to remain in her island home, or even if due caution had been taken with regard to what she ate. "If," says Brown, "they had worked it right and kept her on her food, she might have been alive yet. She was about forty-five or fifty when we found her." But she was supplied to her heart's content with green corn, melons, pumpkin, and squash, and after the brief enjoyment of a new, strange life to her, for a month or five weeks, she sickened and died. She drew her last breath under Nidever's roof, where her home had been from the day when she landed on Santa Barbara beach. The priests acquired her bird-skin dress and all her curious chattels. "The dress the priests have," says Nidever. "I think they sent it to Rome. My wife let them have her needles and all her things." On the same subject Brown remarks: "Nidever gave it [the dress] to the priests, and they sent it to Rome. She had needle-bone with eyes drilled in, a knife made of bone, and another of a piece of wood. She had the wooden knife when I found her, cleaning the seal-skin. She had

nails pointed for catching fish with, and the rope was as nicely twisted with sinews as any rope-maker could do it. And she had bottles made of grass about the size of a gallon demi-john, and we found some dishes of wood with handles. I gave all these things to Nidever."

Juana Maria's life on San Nicolas Island was the exceptional experience of a human being who was not, as was the case with Alexander Selkirk, left alone thousands of miles away from a coast inhabited by a civilized community. She was no great distance from the mainland, where the matin and vesper bell rang morning and night at Christian mis-

sions. Otter-hunters undoubtedly visited the island during her whole residence on it, and the fact of her existence there was evidently known. But not until her very nature was so changed that she had become contented with her lot and had ceased her cry of "Manequauna" to the passing ships, were any measures taken to remove her from her rocky isle. Then they carried her off, unfortunate Juana Maria Better-than-Nothing! White men made her suffer. She lost her babe or babies; she lost her family; she lost the knowledge of her language; and at last, poisoned by the luxuries of a more civilized race, she lost her life.

MY "BUNKY."

BY ROBERT HOWE FLETCHER.

(Author of "The Johnstown Stage," "The Drummer of Co. C," etc.)



He was a private in Troop "J," 11th regiment, U. S. Cavalry, and so was I. We served together up at Fort Ripley, in Idaho Territory, a good many years ago. John

Smith was the

name I was known by on the company rolls, and his name was Daniel Borley. My number was 36, and his was 37, and our bunks stood together in the squad-room. This was twenty-five years ago, before the time when the quartermaster issued woven wire mattresses, sheets and pillow-cases. In our days bunks were made of inch planks, and in the way of bedding bed-sacks filled with clean straw at the corral every Saturday, together with a pair of blankets, was thought to be luxury enough. Indeed the contrast between us and the soldiers of the present was not confined to

"camp and garrison equipage." We were a different set of men altogether. Any old resident of San Francisco will recall the time when our regiment came west by way of the Isthmus (of which we took possession completely from Aspinwall to Panama, driving the Dagos in terror from the road) and how, when we came to San Francisco, the citizens besought the general commanding the division to get us out of the town before we had looted it entirely. It was soon after the war, and while the respectable portion of the disbanded armies had gone back to its home life and regular occupations, the riff-raff was floating about and naturally drifted into the catch-basin of the recruiting office.

We were a hard lot, and when I use the word "we" let it be understood that it is with no sense of pride in the blackguardly achievements of the regiment. Through stress of circumstances I was simply wearing its uniform, that was all, and Dan Bor-